

Chiaroscuro and tenebrism

From the Italian words *chiaro* and *scuro* meaning light and dark, chiaroscuro is a method of representing strongly contrasting tones. Leonardo used it to create compelling effects of light, and by the late 17th century, the term was used to describe any image that employed powerful extremes of light and dark. Caravaggio used the technique in a particularly dramatic way, darkening shadows and using vivid shafts of light to heighten emotional tension in his paintings, a style later called tenebrism, from the Italian word *tenebroso*, meaning murky.

After Caravaggio, Rembrandt van Rijn used chiaroscuro and tenebrism to create psychological effects. Others who used the techniques include Peter Paul Rubens and Diego Velázquez. By the 18th century, in reaction to the excessive drama of the Baroque, Rococo artists rejected the technique, but it was revived by many Romantic artists who followed. Chiaroscuro was also used fairly prominently in 16th-century Italian woodcuts, such as the work of Ugo da Carpi (c.1480–c.1526).



De La Tour, *The New Born*, c.1645